

ENGLISH 96: READINGS, PRESENTATIONS, AND ASSIGNMENTS



Paul Butera
City Colleges of Chicago

English 96: Readings, Presentations, and
Assignments by Professor Paul Butera

This text is disseminated via the Open Education Resource (OER) LibreTexts Project (<https://LibreTexts.org>) and like the thousands of other texts available within this powerful platform, it is freely available for reading, printing, and "consuming."

The LibreTexts mission is to bring together students, faculty, and scholars in a collaborative effort to provide an accessible, and comprehensive platform that empowers our community to develop, curate, adapt, and adopt openly licensed resources and technologies; through these efforts we can reduce the financial burden born from traditional educational resource costs, ensuring education is more accessible for students and communities worldwide.

Most, but not all, pages in the library have licenses that may allow individuals to make changes, save, and print this book. Carefully consult the applicable license(s) before pursuing such effects. Instructors can adopt existing LibreTexts texts or Remix them to quickly build course-specific resources to meet the needs of their students. Unlike traditional textbooks, LibreTexts' web based origins allow powerful integration of advanced features and new technologies to support learning.



LibreTexts is the adaptable, user-friendly non-profit open education resource platform that educators trust for creating, customizing, and sharing accessible, interactive textbooks, adaptive homework, and ancillary materials. We collaborate with individuals and organizations to champion open education initiatives, support institutional publishing programs, drive curriculum development projects, and more.

The LibreTexts libraries are Powered by [NICE CXone Expert](#) and was supported by the Department of Education Open Textbook Pilot Project, the California Education Learning Lab, the UC Davis Office of the Provost, the UC Davis Library, the California State University Affordable Learning Solutions Program, and Merlot. This material is based upon work supported by the National Science Foundation under Grant No. 1246120, 1525057, and 1413739.

Any opinions, findings, and conclusions or recommendations expressed in this material are those of the author(s) and do not necessarily reflect the views of the National Science Foundation nor the US Department of Education.

Have questions or comments? For information about adoptions or adaptations contact info@LibreTexts.org or visit our main website at <https://LibreTexts.org>.

This text was compiled on 06/09/2026

TABLE OF CONTENTS

Licensing

1: Why is English So Difficult-- by Paul Butera

- 1.1: Why is English so Difficult--Reading
- 1.2: Why is English so Difficult?-- Classroom Activity
- 1.3: Why is English so Difficult--Assignment

2: Empathy, the Key to Compelling Communication

- 2.1: Empathy, the Key to Compelling Communication--Reading
- 2.2: Empathy--In-Class Activity
- 2.3: Empathy--Assignment

3: Critical Thinking- A Vital Skill for the Information Age--by Paul Butera

- 3.1: Critical Thinking- a Vital Skill for the Information Age--Readings
- 3.2: Critical Thinking- a Vital Skill for the Information Age--Classroom Activity
- 3.3: Critical Thinking--Assignment

Index

Glossary

Detailed Licensing

Licensing

A detailed breakdown of this resource's licensing can be found in [Back Matter/Detailed Licensing](#).

CHAPTER OVERVIEW

1: Why is English So Difficult-- by Paul Butera

[1.1: Why is English so Difficult--Reading](#)

[1.2: Why is English so Difficult?-- Classroom Activity](#)

[1.3: Why is English so Difficult--Assignment](#)

This page titled [1: Why is English So Difficult-- by Paul Butera](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC-SA 1.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Paul Butera](#).

1.1: Why is English so Difficult--Reading

English and its Eccentricities

The Many Challenges English Presents to Native and Non-Native Speakers

Companion to PowerPoint Presentation

Paul Butera, PhD

Richard Daley College, One of the City Colleges of Chicago

Our society may be divided, but one thing unifies us all. Immigrants and the native born, liberals and conservatives, blue collar and white, Northerners and Southerners, and Westerners and Easterners should all be able to agree that learning to write English effectively is challenging because of the language's complexities and inconsistencies. If you are struggling with run-on sentences, identifying the correct preposition, or writing lucid, comprehensible sentences, you are not alone. We all find English challenging.

Immigrants, for whom English is a second language, must find learning to communicate in English especially frustrating, and their frustration must be compounded by the tendency of many Americans, as commentator Amanda Machado has argued, to view foreign languages "through a lens of suspicion and disdain" (NBC News Digital).

The purpose of this lesson is to explore the distinctive qualities of English that make it both difficult to master and uniquely robust. We look at the history of the language to understand why it is so complicated and its rules are so unpredictable. We also explore how this complexity enabled the evolution of a uniquely rich, adaptable, and nuanced language. Finally, we look at the value of bilingualism, and why it should build the confidence of multi-lingual students rather than make them feel inadequate and isolated. In the end, we believe this information will help native born and immigrant students of English composition recognize that they are not alone in their struggles and that their predecessors faced the same uncertainties in the process of becoming persuasive, confident, and adept writers.

"Crazy Inconsistencies"

In his "English language: Crazy inconsistencies", Professor Albrecht Classen has described this challenge in compelling terms:

Let's face it, English is a crazy language. There is no egg in eggplant, nor ham in hamburger; neither apple nor pine are in pineapple. English muffins aren't English, nor are French fries French. Sweetmeats are candies, while sweetbreads—which aren't sweet—are meat. We take English for granted, but if we explore some of its paradoxes, we find that quicksand is slow, boxing rings are square, and a guinea pig is neither from Guinea nor a pig! ("English language: Crazy inconsistencies.")

As Dr. Claussen indicates, among English's chief challenges are its vast vocabulary, strange idioms, and unpredictable pronunciations. In their article on the BBC Radio 4 website, Beth Sagar-Fenton and Lizzy McNeill point out that the Oxford English Dictionary contains almost 200,000 words, including 47,156 obsolete words and 171,476 active words ("How Many Words").

The possible confusion engendered by the language's vocabulary is evident in the following sentence: *Following his desertion and to avoid his just deserts, the officer devoured his dessert in the deserted desert.* How strange it is that the officer avoids his "just deserts"—his punishment for his desertion—by fleeing to the arid desert to eat his dessert, which is a sweet treat and not at all like punishment or an empty arid landscape.

Of course, the eccentricities of English are not limited to its expansive vocabulary. The rules governing English grammar are often inconsistent and not always applicable. In grammar school, we memorized, "I before E, except after C." However, as we grew up, we discovered that the rule does always apply. Even many common words break the law (e.g. "species," "weird," "leisure," and "foreign").

We also are mystified by some plural conventions:

- The plural forms of some words are the same as their singular forms (e.g. fish, series, elk, and deer).
- Some words that come from Latin have Latinate plurals (e.g. syllabus and syllabi, genus and genera, index and indices, and matrix and matrices).

- Nouns that end in -f or -fe occasionally form their plurals by changing the f to a v and adding s or es. (e.g. calf and calves, live and lives, knife and knives, and half and halves).
- Finally, some plural forms of nouns demand memorization, because there is no clear logic to their formation (child and children, goose and geese, person and people, and mouse and mice).

We are further mystified by inconsistencies in forming past tense. At first, we are relieved to learn a simple rule: If a verb ends in -e, you add -d. If a verb ends in a vowel and a consonant, the consonant is usually doubled before -ed. If a verb ends in consonant and -y, you take off the y and add -ied. But if the word ends in a vowel and -y, you add -ed. “ed” to a verb to indicate past tense except when you don’t. Simple—until we discover spit and spat, swim and swam, sleep and slept, and on and on and on.

Finally, English’s strange idioms often cause more frustration. We urge an actor to break a leg to ensure good luck; we emulate a cold turkey to break an addiction, and when someone dies, we proclaim that they “kicked the bucket.”

Why is English so confusing? Many of those frustrating irregularities, conflicting rules, and exceptions arose from the nation that conquered Great Britain and other cultures that had their own influence. Although its main roots are in the languages of the Germanic tribes that dominated England from c. 450 CE until c. 1150 CE, the Celts, Vikings, Romans, and French introduced their own languages to Britain’s early history, enriching English with unique characteristics that gave the language a special richness. In addition, over the years, many other cultures have made or are still making their own contributions. The global reach of the British Empire, a worldwide system of dependencies—colonies, protectorates, and other territories—assured the influences of many diverse cultures. At its height in 1922, Great Britain controlled roughly a quarter of the world’s landmass population and ruling more the 458 million people.

Five Cultures

A brief look at the five peoples that first shaped the cultures and languages of Great Britain reveal their influence on today’s English and why it is so complex.

The Celtic people were not a unified people but loosely linked together by similar languages, customs, and religious practices. The Celts did not conquer Britain but infiltrated it between 500 to 100 BCE, bringing the Iron Age to Britain.

The family of six living Celtic languages is divided into two groups: Brythonic and Goidelic. The Brythonic languages include Welsh, Cornish, and Breton. Welsh and Breton are continuously living languages. Cornish, the language of Cornwall in southwestern England, became extinct but was revived in the 20th century. Breton is still spoken in Brittany. The Goidelic languages include Irish, Manx, and Scottish Gaelic. This group of language originated in Ireland. The other two Goidelic languages are associated with the Isle of Man (Manx) and Scotland (Scottish Gaelic).

The five Celtic languages spoken in Ancient Britain were very different from each other, which is evident when you compare the phrase “I live in Wales”, as written in the five versions of the language:

- Welsh - *Dw i'n byw yng Nghymru*
- Cornish - *Trigys ov yn Kembra*
- Irish - *Tá mé i mo chónaí sa Bhreatain Bheag*
- Scots Gaelic - *Tha mi a' fuireach anns a' Chuimrigh*
- Manx - *Ta mee cummal 'sy Vretyn*

The Romans brought Latin to Ancient Britain. Julius Caesar invaded England in 55 BCE and re-invaded a year later, but he failed to conquer the island nation. In 43 CE, Emperor Claudius launched a more ambitious invasion; the Roman conquest was complete in 77 CE; 333 years later the Britons expelled the Romans and won their independence. Latin’s influence in Roman Britain was somewhat limited, and it did not displace the Celtic languages, which remained the speech of the common people. Christianity would have a greater influence in introducing elements of Latin.

The language of the German tribes of northern Germany and southern Scandinavia had a much greater influence on modern English than Latin. The languages of the Angles, Jutes, and Saxons formed the basis of Anglo Saxon, which was the dominant language in England from c. 450 CE until c. 1150 CE. Approximately 30 percent of the modern English vocabulary is of Anglo-Saxon origin, which is the source of many of our functional linking words (prepositions, conjunctions, and articles), such as to, from, and, but, however, when, since, the, and an). We can attribute many of our most familiar nouns to the Anglo Saxons, including mother, father, one, two, ten, house, home, bread, water, harvest, cow, sun, eat, drink, talk, good, bad, old, and young.

The seafaring Vikings, or Norsemen, brought Old Norse to Britain and introduced Scandinavian elements into English. The Vikings traveled great distances from their homelands (modern Norway, Sweden, and Denmark.) in small open boats as far as North

America to the west, Russia to the east, Lapland to the north, and the Mediterranean World (Constantinople) and Iraq (Baghdad) to the south. Great Britain's "Viking Age" lasted from approximately 800 to 1150. Approximately 35,000 Vikings may have relocated to England. Eventually, these newcomers settled across the country, marrying into local families. Words such as sky, skin, wagon originated in the language of the Vikings.

William, the Duke of Normandy, was the last leader to successfully invade England. In 1066, he defeated Harold, King of England, at the Battle of Hastings and made Norman French the official language of England for administration, education, literature, and law. Anglo-Saxon remained the language spoken of the general public. However, Norman French had an influence on modern English, and many of the words we speak today are of French origin, including government, law, pork, army, art, literature, shirt, and cuisine.

An Agent of Global Unity

Of course, the influence of these five cultures on the English was just the beginning of the evolution of the language, which has become the nearest thing we have to a global language and an agent of global unity. Despite its challenging complexity, people throughout the world have adopted English in addition to their native language. According to Statista, approximately 1.5 billion people speak English natively or as a second language, making it the most spoken language in the world ("The most spoken languages worldwide") and it has become the global lingua franca of science, government and diplomacy, media, art, and entertainment.

It seems odd that the nation with the most English speakers in the world—the United States—also has a tradition of linguistic racism and resistance to multilingualism. Nooshan Ashari and Stephen Krashen of the USC Rossier School of Education define this "as the mistreatment, devaluation, and acts of discrimination towards people based on their language use or perceptions about their ethnicities" ("Confronting Linguistic Racism").

America's version of this bigotry even had a pseudo-scientific basis. As late as 1947, according to Sarah Vicol of Stanford University, anti-immigrant prejudice encouraged respected researchers to claim "that bilingualism was a cause of mental retardation, arguing that the amount of brain "capacity" required to store two distinct languages systems meant less space for other knowledge and abilities ("The Politics of Bilingualism in the United States").

The pernicious belief that knowing more than one language is a negative persists. As Amanda Machado points out, almost four in 10 Latinos say they experienced some kind of harassment related to their ethnicity. According to psychiatrist Paul C. Hollinger, discrimination can "be potentially destructive in terms of undermining a child's development and sense of self—by eliciting distress, [fear](#), [shame](#), self-disgust, and [rage](#)". This attitude had on personal impact on Machado who explains how living in the United had taught her "to become ashamed of her own father and believe that his deeply accented and imperfect English made our family less worthy than others" ("The Role of Language in Bias, Prejudice and Violence").

Professional Communicator Diana Drake also speaks movingly about her struggle with an "overwhelming feeling of inadequacy" prompted by linguistic racism.

Eighteen years later, I still recall the shame of being scolded for my inability to communicate in the appropriate way – in this case, fully in English. . . . I was wounded and crying. I remember thinking to myself that I wouldn't speak in class unless I absolutely had to. It was an overwhelming feeling of inadequacy; something a four-year-old girl should never experience ("Student's Struggle to speak English").

However, according to Drake, her struggle with English turned out to be a blessing. Not knowing English forced her to work harder and stay focused in class. She writes, "I paid close attention to how people spoke and pronounced words. When I was tired and wanted to stop, I had to keep studying" ("Student's Struggle to speak English").

Drake's admission highlights a great irony articulated by Machado:

There is no pride in Spanish/English bilingualism, even though several studies have proven the [many cognitive benefits](#) of speaking two languages: [increased focus](#), [better problem-solving skills](#), [delaying the onset of dementia](#) and even a link to [higher levels of empathy](#)" ("How the U.S. taught me that Spanish was shameful"). Drake herself speaks of impact of her bilingualism on her empathy: The fact that I am not a native English speaker has made me more empathetic. It has helped me truly understand why diversity of thought is such a strength in the workplace, and, ironically, has made me a far more effective communicator" ("Student's Struggle to speak English").

In the end, America's attitude about bilingualism has put it at a cultural and competitive disadvantage. For example, people throughout Europe speak multiple languages. According to the U.S. Census, 20% of Americans speak two or more languages,

which compares to 54% of Europeans. According to Alberto Nardelli, The percentages of people who are able to speak two or more languages are particularly high in Luxembourg (98%) Latvia (95%), the Netherlands (94%), Malta (93%) Slovenia and Lithuania (92% each), and Sweden (91%) (Alberto Nardelli).”

“If they can do it. . .”

The global spread of English suggests that we can all overcome its complexity and take advantage of its rich diversity. There are an estimated 1.5 billion English speakers in the world. If they can do it, who are we to say we cannot? Our review of the history of English explains why we are intimidated by its challenges. The fault is not in us or in our abilities, but in the nature of the beast itself. And, if we are an immigrant who grew up in a home in which the dominant language was not English, we should not see that as an embarrassment but as a point of pride. Moreover, as a bilingual person, we have likely developed some cognitive strengths that will assist us in our studies.

We also know that the struggle will be worth the effort, because the language’s complexities and inconsistencies are signs of its strengths. English is not a single language, but an amalgamation of many languages that has captured the essences of a multitude of cultures. We have a vast vocabulary to learn, but that only means we have a wealth of words from which to choose. We do not have the benefit of rigid rules that simplify writing, but we do have the advantage of a highly adaptable vehicle for expression.

In the end, the challenge is daunting, the path meandering, and the hours long and, at times, tedious, but we would not have it any other way.

Works Cited

Ashari, Nooshan and Stephen Krashen. “Confronting linguistic racism: As our world grows more globalized, our acceptance of others—and their accents—is paramount.” USC Rossiter School of Education. December 4, 2023.

<https://rossier.usc.edu/news-insights/news/confronting-linguistic-racism>

Diana Drake, “Student’s Struggle to Speak English Leads to a Career as a Communicator.” Wharton Youth Program. Wharton University of Pennsylvania. April 12, 2019.

<https://globalyouth.wharton.upenn.edu/articles/student-essays/struggle-speak-english-better-communicator/>

Holinger, Paul C. “The Role of Language in Bias, Prejudice, and Violence: Language has the power to hurt, but it also has the power to heal.” *Psychology Today*. October 19, 2022.

Machado, Amanda. “How the U.S. taught me that Spanish was shameful,” March 26, 2019, *Think: Opinion, Analysis, Essays*, NBC News Digital.

<https://www.nbcnews.com/think/opinion/how-u-s-taught-me-spanish-was-shameful-ncna986746>

Alberto Nardelli, “Most Europeans can speak multiple languages. UK and Ireland not so much,” *The Guardian*, September 26, 2014 www.theguardian.com/news/datablog/2014/sep/26/europeans-multiple-languages-uk-ireland

Sarah Vicol, “The Politics of Bilingualism in the United States: A New Perspective on the Immigration Debate,” *Stanford Undergraduate Research Journal*, Vol. 18 No 1 (2019) Spring 2019

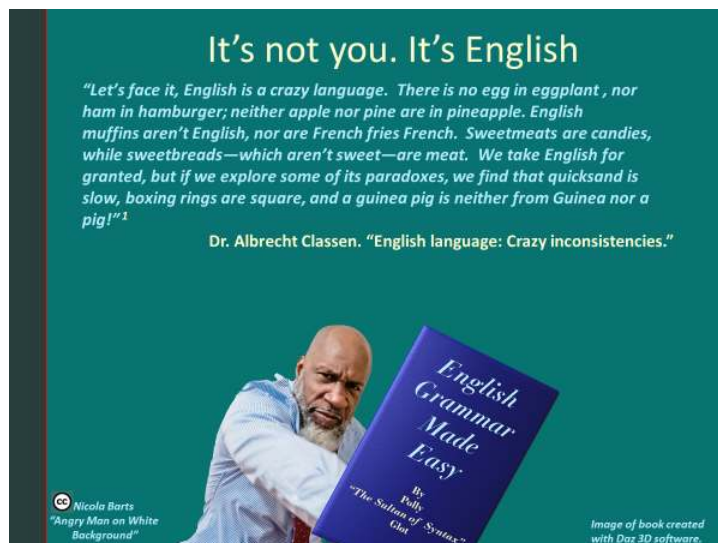
<https://ojs.stanford.edu/ojs/index.php/surj/article/view/1266>

This page titled [1.1: Why is English so Difficult--Reading](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC-SA 1.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Paul Butera](#).

SECTION OVERVIEW

1.2: Why is English so Difficult?-- Classroom Activity

You can download this [presentation](#) as a PowerPoint slideshow.



Our Quirky Language

The zookeeper had enough dough to buy the doe, but he needed many more bucks for the buck. Staggered by the extra cost, he thought, "Why does this sexist charge so much more for stags than does?" The dealer admitted that male deer were dearer to him than does, so, he always charged more bucks for stags than does. In reflection, he realized that that was wrong. Moreover, he dearly loved the duo of deer and longed to keep the deer duet together. So, to avoid separating the doe from the stag, he offered a killer deal for both. Nor did he want to separate the baby deer from its parents, and he was moved by the zookeeper's fawning over their offspring and he threw in the fawn for free, saying, "Leave no hind behind."



CC BY "Brown Deer" by Pi

More Quirkiness

Following his desertion and to avoid his just deserts, the officer devoured his desert in the deserted desert.



pbuttera

Image created with Daz 3D software.

Curiouser and Curiouser

- As our deer family and officer demonstrate, many words, although spelled the same, have various pronunciations and meanings.
- Grammatical "rules" are inconsistent and not always applicable. We remember, "I before E, except after C," from grammar school; however, it is another rule that does not always apply (e.g. "species," "weird," "leisure," or "foreign,").
- In contrast, few of us recall the rule requiring us to place multiple adjectives before a noun in rank order according to opinion, size, age, shape, color, origin, material, purpose. However, most of us follow it subconsciously. If you are unsure, try saying "old silly fool" without feeling something is off.
- Add "ed" to a verb to indicate past tense except when you don't. It is not "sticked", "raned", "drived", "eated", or "sleaped."
- We cram English with strange idioms. We urge an actor to break a leg to ensure good luck; we emulate a cold turkey to break an addiction, and when someone dies, we proclaim that they kicked the bucket.

Complexity—A Source of Strength

- English's extraordinary complexity, vast vocabulary, strange idioms, and unpredictable pronunciation reflect the many influences that shaped it.
- According to some linguists, English is one of the largest languages in terms of word count. Only a limited amount of dictionary entries support this assertion. The Oxford English Dictionary contains almost 200,000 words. It includes 47,156 obsolete words and 171,476 active words.²
- Many of those frustrating irregularities, conflicting rules, and exceptions rose from the cultures that conquered Great Britain or were occupied by it and became part of the British Empire.
- Although its main roots are in the languages of the Germanic tribes that dominated England from c. 450 CE until c. 1150 CE and the Vikings, England had several other official languages that introduced unique characteristics that brought a special richness to our language.

Complexity—A Source of Strength

- Let's look at England's original languages to appreciate their influence and how our language's complexity is, in fact, a source of strength.



The Celtic Language

Irish, Scots Gaelic, Welsh, Brythonic, Manx, and Cornish were spoken in Britain by the Celts beginning in 500 BCE.



The Celts were not a unified people but loosely linked together by similar languages, customs, and religious practices.

- Infiltrated Britain between 500 to 100 B.C.
- Brought the Iron Age to Britain

Translations of "I live in Wales" into forms of Celtic spoken in Ancient Britain demonstrate how different they were from each other.

- Welsh - *Dw i'n byw yng Nghymru*
- Cornish - *Trigys ov yn Kembra*
- Irish - *Tá mé i mo chónaí sa Bhreatain Bheag*
- Scots Gaelic - *Tha mi a' fuireach anns a' Chuimrigh*
- Manx - *Ta mee cummal 'sy Vretyn*

Celtic Confusion

Thousands of Britains still speak the Celtic languages, including Welsh. The Welsh name of a village in Anglesey in Wales is often credited with the title for longest town name in Europe.³



Jimmy Kimmel Tries Celtic

Llanfairpwllgwyngyllgogerychwyrndrobwllllantysiliogogogoch

Please access video here: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=WwYAuv8cQ1Y>

The Roman Invasion

Scots Gaelic

Irish

Brythonic Welsh

Cornish

Language: Latin

Antonine Wall

Hadrian's Wall

Julius Caesar invades Britain (43 AD)

Emperor Honorius tells Britain to look to its own defenses from then on (410 A.D.)

Germanic Tribes Settle in England

Old English was spoken and written in Anglo-Saxon Britain from c. 450 CE until c. 1150 CE.

UNITED KINGDOM

GERMAN

Migration of Germanic Tribes

- Angles
- Jutes
- Saxons

Approximately 30 percent of the modern English vocabulary is of Anglo-Saxon origin, including

- Functional linking words (prepositions, conjunctions, and articles), such as *to*, *from*, *and*, *but*, *however*, *when*, *since*, *the*, and *an*.
- Everyday nouns, verbs, and adjectives, such as *mother*, *father*, *one*, *two*, *ten*, *house*, *home*, *bread*, *water*, *harvest*, *cow*, *sun*, *eat*, *drink*, *talk*, *good*, *bad*, *old*, and *young*.

The Opening of Beowulf:

The First Great English Epic in Anglo Saxon



Please access video here: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Ch_Gwv2d4d

13

The Vikings

The seafaring Vikings, or Norsemen, were originally from Norway, Sweden, and Denmark.) From there they travelled great distances on small open as far as North America to the west, Russia to the east, Lapland to the north and the Mediterranean World (Constantinople) and Iraq (Baghdad) to the south.

"The Viking Age" lasted from approximately 800 to 1150. As many as 35,000 Vikings may have relocated to England. Eventually, these newcomers settled across the country, marrying into local families. They spoke Old Norse, which influenced the English language in many ways. Words such as sky, skin, wagon originated with the language of the Vikings.



Language: Old Norse



Danelaw: area controlled by Danish law.



Array of Viking shields created with Daz 3D software.

14

The Normans



CC Gioele Fazzari, Close-up Photo of a Knight



The Battle of Hastings, Bayeux Tapestry

Battle of Hastings
William the Conqueror
Defeats
Harold, King of England, and
makes Norman French
England's official language

15

Complexity Provides Extraordinary Variety

Gaelic, Celtic

Bog, clan, crag, galore, glen, hubbub, inch, pet, plaid, shanty, slogan, trouser, whisky

Latin

Article, cardio, circus, collar, condemn, ferocious, maternity, normal, oval, superior

Old English

Ablaze, aboard, above, acre, back, , bake , bare, cat, cesspool, cunning, date, dwindle, earn, earth, fat, field film, gloomy, glide, go, gut, hack, hoop, horse, hose, , indoor, jerk, job, jump, knee, knew, ladder, lady , limp, lust, lynch, mother, quake, quick, rake , read, sap, stone, town, tree, upload, vat, vixen, wonky, work, year

Old Norse

Anger, awe, are, awkward, axle, bag, ball berserker, bull, cake cast, die, dirt, egg, fellow flat, fog, give, guest, gun, happy, heathen, hell, ill, irk, kid, knife knot, leg, ling, mire, mistake, odd, outlaw, plow, race, raft, root, rotten, scale, scarf, seat, skill, skin, take, trust, ugly, until, Viking, wand whisk, window, wing

Norman French

Fashion, cabbage, candle, castle, cauldron, causeway, catch, cherry, mug, poor, wait, war, warrior, wicket

10

The Key to Grammar

Although English rules of grammar are inconsistent, various principles can guide us. Stanley Fish offers one of the best:

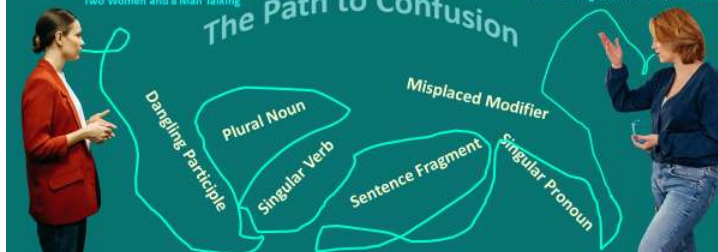
"If one understands that a sentence is a structure of logical relationships and that the number of relationships involved is finite, one understands too that there is only one error to worry about, the error of being illogical and only one rule to follow: make sure that every component of your sentences is related to the other components in a way that is clear and unambiguous."⁴

Stanley Fish, *How to Write a Sentence: And How to Read One* 



cottonbro studio,
Two Women and a Man Talking

Karolina Grabowska,
Women Having a Conversation Indoors



Language without Leads to Confusion, Misunderstanding, and Conflict



Golden Rules for the English Languages Precepts and Guidelines you Can Trust

- Ensure your subjects and verbs agree.
- Be consistent with your tenses.
- Use complete sentences.
- Capitalize where needed.
- Use the right pronouns and prepositions.
- Use conjunctions to link ideas and clauses.



Eddie Suazo posted this video of a man attacking Spanish speakers, an all too common incident. (click picture above to launch video.)⁷

We Must Promote Bilingualism

While we should strive to communicate clearly and correctly, we must also recognize the value of bilingualism and overcome the tendency of many Americans, as commentator Amanda Machado has argued, to “view Spanish through a lens of suspicion and disdain.”⁵

As late as 1947, according to Sarah Vicol of Stanford University, anti-immigrant prejudice encouraged respected researchers to claim “that bilingualism was a cause of mental retardation, arguing that the amount of brain “capacity” required to store two distinct languages systems meant less space for other knowledge and abilities.”⁶

Machado points out that almost four in 10 Latinos say they experienced some kind of harassment related to their ethnicity, such as the attack on Spanish documented in the video posted on this slide. This attitude had on personal impact on Machado who explains how living in the United had taught her “to become ashamed of her own father and believe that his deeply accented and imperfect English made our family less worthy than others.”⁷

We Must Promote Bilingualism

However, bilingualism has many benefits. It

- Facilitates improved performance in education.
- Helps people learn additional languages.
- Enables people to earn 5% to 20% more on average than those who are not bilingual.⁸
- Creates more employment opportunities.
- Delays the onset of Dementia and Alzheimer's disease.⁹
- Improves cognitive flexibility, problem-solving skills, and cultural identity.
- Promotes improved and faster recoveries from strokes.¹⁰
- Widens people's horizons and encourages tolerance.
- Provides greater access to another culture.
- Fosters self-confidence.



CC Camille Kulig and DMA Teens, "Brain"

21

Bilingualism Encourages Engagement



CC Diva Plavalaguna, Multiracial Group of People by the table.

22

A Disadvantage

America's attitude about bilingualism has put it at a competitive disadvantage. For example, people throughout Europe speak multiple languages. According to the U.S. Census, 20% of Americans speak two or more languages, which compares to 54% of Europeans. The percentages of people who are able to speak two or more languages are particularly high in Luxembourg (98%), Latvia (95%), the Netherlands (94%), Malta (93%), Slovenia and Lithuania (92% each), and Sweden (91%).¹¹

In his documentary, *Where to Invade Next*, Director Michael Moore explored education in Finland and discovered that many Finnish students were fluent in many languages.



Michael Moore Asks a Question

No wonder Director Michael Moore looked shocked in his 2015 film *Where to Invade Next* when he asked several Finnish students how many languages they spoke.



Please access this video here <https://www.facebook.com/watch/?v=636057313254225>



25

This page titled [1.2: Why is English so Difficult?-- Classroom Activity](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC-SA 1.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Paul Butera](#).

1.3: Why is English so Difficult--Assignment

Assignment for Lecture

English and its Eccentricities

The Many Challenges English Presents to Native and Non-Native Speakers

In this lesson, we focused on the challenges that we all face in becoming persuasive, confident, and adept writers. English is a rich amalgam of elements derived from a multitude of languages and other influences. Today, it is a truly global language that reflects a wide range of cultures. With its complex interaction of various grammars, its inconsistent rules, and its vast vocabulary of almost 200,000 words, English is difficult to master, humbling both its native born and non-native students. However, this complexity has enabled the evolution of a uniquely rich, adaptable, and nuanced language.

Your assignment is to discuss your own experience in striving to become a persuasive, confident, and adept writer. In a short essay of about 300 words, please review your own struggles to overcome its challenges and your personal views on its strengths. If you are bilingual, please consider how knowing more than one language has been a benefit or not. Here are a few questions to get you started. We do not expect you to answer any or all of these questions. They are intended to jumpstart your thought process.

- What is the most difficult writing challenge you have faced or face? How are you dealing with it?
- Do you enjoy writing? If so, what makes it enjoyable?
- Do you dread writing? If so, what do about writing do you dislike?
- From your personal perspectives, what are the strengths of the English language? What are its weaknesses?
- Do you get frustrated with English complexities and inconsistencies? How are you managing these challenges?
- Have you ever experienced linguistic racism? Why do you feel it was directed at you? How did respond to it both externally and internally?

This page titled [1.3: Why is English so Difficult--Assignment](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC-SA 1.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Paul Butera](#).

CHAPTER OVERVIEW

2: Empathy, the Key to Compelling Communication

[2.1: Empathy, the Key to Compelling Communication--Reading](#)

[2.2: Empathy--In-Class Activity](#)

[2.3: Empathy--Assignment](#)

This page titled [2: Empathy, the Key to Compelling Communication](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC-SA](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Paul Butera](#).

2.1: Empathy, the Key to Compelling Communication--Reading

Empathy and Audience

When people read your essay, they are constantly judging you, the writer. Are you credible? Are you on their side? Can they trust what you say? Can they relate? Your basic task in creating a persuasive essay is to form a partnership with the reader, and that requires you know your audience as well as you can. Knowing your reader seems like an obvious piece of advice, but it is something many of us do not do thoroughly enough. Occasionally, we do not look at it as a distinct task, and we assume that we already know the audience well enough. Consequently, we should consider this major step in essay writing, why it is important, and how to perform it effectively.

Researching your audience is one your most important first steps, because it should shape your essay's strategy, research, structure, tone, and word choice. Knowing your readers enables you to determine:

- What information to include and the order in which to share it.
- To decide what NOT to include.
- How to meet your readers' intellectual and emotional needs.
- How to answer potential questions, anticipate concerns, solve problems, and avoid topics, words, and ideas that some might find offensive.
- The voice you should use to engage your readers and convince them of your credibility.

Words Matter

The wrong word, tone, or approach can undermine your essay's logic and antagonize your reader. Language has enormous power, because it enables us to connect with the world outside of human consciousness. We can never fully know what is in someone else's mind or how others see us, but language provides us with a slender bridge to cross that divide if only momentarily. Words can inspire love and provoke anger, speak truth, and disseminate lies, explain mysteries, and engender confusion, provide solace, and intensify despair, define society's values, and undermine them, and create and destroy civilizations. So, we must handle them gingerly, as if they were a highly unstable, combustible substance for they can ignite controversies if our audience misunderstands our meaning.

For example, many words and phrases we have used casually throughout our lives may, unknown to us, be deeply offensive to others, especially people of different ethnicities, races, sexual orientation, gender, and capabilities. For example,

- OCD—many of us use the acronym for obsessive-compulsive disorder in a self-deprecating way to describe ourselves as overly tidy and organized. However, this practice trivializes a serious mental condition that is challenging to people who suffer from it.
- Smooth Brain—a slang term for stupid. It also is the non-scientific term for lissencephaly, a set of brain disorders in which the surface of the brain appears smooth. Children with this condition often suffer significant developmental delays, and their life expectancy may be shortened.
- Oriental—is considered insulting when used to refer to Asians, because the word is most associated with objects (e.g., oriental rugs). It also harkens back to a period when racist attitudes toward Asians were even more common than today. Degrading depictions of Asians in popular culture were ubiquitous.

So, knowing your audience is critical to writing compelling essays and navigating your way through the verbal minefield of a diverse society. The writer's most effective asset in meeting this challenge is cultivating and exercising empathy, which is invaluable to communication and human relationships. Empathy encompasses understanding, awareness, sensitivity, and vicariously imagining the feelings, thoughts, ideas, and experiences of another—past or present—without having them communicated in an objectively explicit manner.

What Others Have Said about Empathy

Our best writers often attribute their success to their skillful use of empathy. Poet Nikki Giovanni downplays the common overused advice to new writers—"write what you know"—and emphasizes the importance of empathy: "Writers don't write from experience, although many are hesitant to admit that they don't . . . If you wrote from experience, you'd get maybe one book, maybe three poems. Writers write from empathy."

Popular author Neil Gaiman, for example, argues, "Fiction gives us empathy: it puts us inside the minds of other people, gives us the gift of seeing the world through their eyes. Fiction is a lie that tells us true things, over and over." Gaiman discusses the

importance of empathy in writing fiction, but his advice applies to nonfiction as well. Both fiction and non-fiction tell stories, because that is the best way to deliver information. From Homer wandering from campfire to campfire relating tales about the Trojan War and its aftermath to the CEO reporting third quarter results, speakers, novelists, leaders, and reporters use narrative to convey the messages they wish to impart. In “Stories in Our Bones,” Storyteller Dr. Geoff Mead emphasizes that our brains are hardwired for narrative, and he stresses that point by speaking of “an indigenous people whose name for human being, when literally translated, is ‘featherless storytelling creature.’”

Essayist Joan Didion provided one of the best discussions of the importance of narrative in the opening of her essay, “Slouching Towards Bethlehem”:

We tell ourselves stories in order to live. The princess is caged in the consulate. The man with the candy will lead the children into the sea. The naked woman on the ledge outside the window on the sixteenth floor is a victim of accidie, or the naked woman is an exhibitionist, and it would be “interesting” to know which. . . . We look for the sermon in the suicide, for the social or moral lesson in the murder of five. We interpret what we see, select the most workable of the multiple choices.

Our finest novelists are experts in narrative and, as we have seen, they understand that readers prefer characters with whom they can identify. In the same way, when we write an essay, we must be sure that our readers can empathize—as in relate to or identify with—who we are and what we say.

They also value empathy, because it is a critical element of creativity. Notre Dame University Professor Chris Adkins clarifies the links between empathy and creativity in his essay, “How Does Empathy Influence Creativity?”:

Empathy begins with attention. Creativity does too. In both cases, you pay attention to the data you take in. In Latin, attention means to “stretch toward.” When you empathize with someone, you’re stretching outside of yourself and stretching into that person’s world. This empathy then links to problem-solving because you must first decide not only what the problem is, but who has the problem.

Clearly, there is abundant evidence that empathy is fundamental to knowing your audience, superior writing, and creativity. However, a key question remains; how do we become more empathetic? Writer Claire Cain Miller is a powerful proponent of empathy:

Research has shown that empathy makes people better managers and workers, and better family members and friends. But it’s bigger than just its personal effect. We’re all in this together, and researchers say that connection and compassion are crucial to a sustainable and humane future.

Miller also offers some answers to our final challenge. As part of its *A Year of Living Better* series, *The New York Times* published her article “How to Be More Empathetic”, which discusses practical steps to fostering empathy. She recommends a three-step process:

In Step One, you become more attentive to people outside of your social, cultural, and professional group to discover how they think and live.

- Become more attentive to others, especially in conversations. Be careful to observe non-verbal clues.
- Explore unfamiliar environments and cultures through new experiences, such as attending a house of worship of another religion or attending an event of another culture, such as a Pride Parade, a Cinco de Mayo festival, or a Bar/Bat Mitzvah.
- If you find that someone’s behavior, beliefs, or feelings upset you, strive to determine where they are coming from. Consider their backgrounds, their daily challenges, and their past experiences.

In Step Two, intensify your exploration of other perspectives by engaging in activities that take you outside your comfort zone.

- Volunteer for community efforts, such as a community garden, a food pantry, an advocacy group, or a school board. For example, participating in events involving people in need is an excellent way to engage directly with the homeless and others who are economically or socially disadvantaged.
- Recognize that all people including ourselves, are biased. We all grow up in singular environments isolated from other cultures.
- Read books that enable you to discover how others live and think. Research has demonstrated that people who read literary fiction are more empathetic than those who do not. Several medical schools, for example, encourage future physicians to read narrative fiction, because it helps them develop superior bedside manners and diagnostic skills.

In Step Three, engage in rigorous self-evaluation to identify and address your biases and evaluate your progress in becoming more empathetic.

- Since we are often unaware of our own biases, explore ways to discover them. You could take a quiz designed to help you reveal their unconscious biases. Examine your behavior in social situations, think about cultural differences, and how you respond to cultural stimuli.
- Explore these issues:
 - Do you ever contemplate issues related to race, sexual orientation, ethnicity, gender, and access? How often?
 - Do you watch movies, plays, or TV shows or read books that portray people of diverse cultures?
 - Do you ever find yourself in social settings with people who identify differently than you?

Works Cited

Nikki Giovanni quoted in *Black Women Writers at Work*. Edited by Claudia Tate. Reprinted by Haymarket Books in paperback, January 10, 2023. (The January 1, 1983, original edition is out-of-print.)

<https://bookshop.org/p/books/black-w...=9781642598407>

Neil Gaiman, "Introduction," *Fahrenheit 451: A Novel* by Ray Bradbury, Harper Collins Publishers, New York, 2013.

Dr. Geoff Mead. "Stories in Our Bones," Centre for Narrative Leadership. <https://hermesconsulting.wordpress.c...-in-our-bones/>

Joan Didion, "Slouching Towards Bethlehem", *Slouching Towards Bethlehem: Essays*. Farrar, Strauss and Giroux. New York. 1968.

Chris Adkins, "How does empathy influence creativity?," "A Scholar's Perspective"

Claire Cain Miller, "How to Be More Empathetic," *A Year of Living Better*, The New York Times. January 31, 2019.

This page titled [2.1: Empathy, the Key to Compelling Communication--Reading](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC-SA 1.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Paul Butera](#).

2.2: Empathy--In-Class Activity

This slideshow is downloadable as a PowerPoint file [here](#).

We have discussed the importance of knowing your audience to write a persuasive essay. Your goal is to form partnerships with your readers, and that requires you to study your audience. Your understanding of their backgrounds, needs, and preferences should guide your essay's strategy, research, structure, tone, and word choice. The best way to develop this understanding is to use empathy. This is especially true if your audience includes people with different cultures and backgrounds than yours.

Strong writers focus on nurturing their empathy and learning how other people think. This includes working to identify your personal biases. Thus, they often examine their behaviors in social situations and review attitudes to assess their level of empathy and how well they relate to people from other cultures.

Your in-class assignment is to do your own self-evaluation of your own level of empathy and summarize your conclusions in a short essay of about 300 words. Here are a few questions to get you started. We do not expect you to answer any or all of these questions. They are intended to jumpstart your thinking.

- Do you ever contemplate issues related to race, sexual orientation, ethnicity, gender, and access? How often?
- Do you watch movies, plays, or TV shows or read books that portray people of diverse cultures?
- Do you ever find yourself in social settings with people of other backgrounds or preferences?
- Are you attentive to others, especially in conversations? Are you aware of non-verbal clues?
- When you disagree with someone or find the behavior and attitudes off-putting, do you get angry and dismiss them or do you try to understand where they are coming from?
- If someone takes a position on an issue that is counter to your own, do you reject it out-of-hand or do you consider it seriously and see if your views need adjustment?

Know Your Audience

Empathy, the Key to Compelling Communication

Walk in Your Reader's Shoes



By Paul J. Butera, PhD
City Colleges of Chicago

 Freedom House, "Syrian Refugees"

NOTE:

Please Refer to PowerPoint's "Note Page View" for Additional Resources, References, and Fair Use Clarifications.

Know your Audience

Knowing your readers enables you to determine

- What information to include and the order in which to share it.
- To decide what NOT to include.
- How to meet your readers' intellectual and emotional needs.
- How to answer potential questions, anticipate concerns, solve problems, and avoid potentially offensive topics, words, and ideas.
- The best voice to engage your readers and convince them of your credibility.



 Writers Forum, "Audience"

Language is Power, Use with Care

"Each of you possesses the most powerful, dangerous, and subversive trait that natural selection ever devised. It's a piece of neural audio technology for rewiring other people's minds . . . Just imagine the sense of wonder in a baby when it first discovers that, merely by uttering a sound, it can get objects to cross a room as if by magic and maybe even into its mouth."

Mark Pagel, Biologist
Reading University¹



CC Rodrigo Silva, "Lookin' Surprised"

The Value of Language

Language has enormous power, because it enables us to connect with the world outside of human consciousness.

We can never fully know what is in someone else's mind or how others see us, but language provides us with a slender bridge to cross that divide if only momentarily.

The power of words enables us to

- Form complex, systematic, and
- diverse thoughts and concepts.
- Create communities and civilizations.
- Shape personal and collective world-views.
- Describe the past, explain the present, and envision the future.
- Share ideas, hopes, and life experiences.



CC Ketut Subiyanto, "Woman Embracing another Person with Empathy"

Handle with Care

"Handle them carefully, for words have more power than atom bombs."

British Politician Pearl Strachan Hurd²

Words can inspire love and provoke anger, speak truth and disseminate lies, explain mysteries and engender confusion, provide solace and intensify despair, define society's values



and undermine them, and create and destroy civilizations. So, we must handle them gingerly, as if they were a highly unstable, combustible substance for they will explode.

 Redmond Bluestone, "Atomic Bomb Explosion 2"

The Danger of Not Knowing

If you don't know your audience and their sensitivities, you can undermine your credibility with a word that seems perfectly innocent to you but extremely offensive to others.

Verbal sensitivity—to some extent—has become deeply individualized, which requires us to become knowledgeable about the many cultures and perspectives that are different from ours.



 Yan Kruka, "Group of People Smiling and Standing Near Brown Wooden Table Raising Hands"

A Verbal Minefield

Many words and phrases we have used casually throughout our lives may, unknown to us, be deeply offensive to others, such as

- **OCD**—many of us use the acronym for obsessive-compulsive disorder in a self-deprecating way to describe ourselves as overly tidy and organized. However, this practice trivializes a serious mental condition that is challenging to people who suffer from it.
- **Peanut Gallery**—referring to the cheap seats in the uppermost balcony of a theater, it was used to describe people thought to be insignificant and rowdy. Moreover, it has racist connotations, because, in segregated societies, it is where people of color were required to sit.
- **Smooth Brain**—a slang term for stupid. It also is the non-scientific term for lissencephaly, a set of brain disorders in which the surface of the brain appears smooth. Children with this condition often suffer significant developmental delays, and their life expectancy may be shortened.
- **Oriental**—is considered insulting when used to refer to Asians, because the word is most associated with objects (e.g., oriental rugs). It also harkens back to a period when racist attitudes toward Asians were even more common than today. Degrading depictions of Asians in popular culture were ubiquitous.

9

Empathy

The most effective way to address this challenge is cultivating and exercising empathy, which is invaluable to communication and human relationships. Empathy encompasses understanding, awareness, sensitivity, and vicariously imagining the feelings, thoughts, ideas, and experiences of another—past or present—without having them communicated in an objectively explicit manner.



CC Frank Willer, "Empathy"

10



Photo: Neil Gaiman
<https://neilgaiman.com>

Our Most Distinguished Authors Champion Empathy's Critical Role in their Writing³

"Fiction gives us empathy: it puts us inside the minds of other people, gives us the gift of seeing the world through their eyes. Fiction is a lie that tells us true things, over and over."⁴

Neil Gaiman, author of *The Sandman*, *Stardust*, *American Gods*, *The Graveyard Book*, *Caroline*, etc.



Demand Empathy

*"This is a wonderful planet, and it is being completely destroyed by people who have too much money and power and no empathy."*⁵

Alice Walker, author of *The Color Purple*, *The Temple of My Familiar*, *Possessing the Secret Joy*, etc.

Alice Walker illustration by Jillian Tamaki for The New York Times Published December 13, 2018

12

Distinguished Authors Champion Empathy's Value

*"Empathy is about finding echoes of another person in yourself."*⁶

Mohsin Hamid, author of *Moth, Smoke*, *The Reluctant Fundamentalist*, etc.




*"Empathy is what separates human beings from teenage boys."*⁷

Victor LaValle, author of *Slapboxing with Jesus*, *The Changeling*, *Big Machine*, *The Ecstatic*, *The Devil in Silver*, etc.

Photo: Penguin Random House Speakers Bureau, <https://www.prfspeakers.com/speaker/mohsin-hamid>

Photo: Teddy Wolff on Publishers Weekly <https://www.publishersweekly.com/pw/by-topic/authors/profiles/article/91203-victor-lavalle-a-westward-howl.html>

13

Empathy and the Essay

Novelists understand that readers prefer characters with whom they can identify. In the same way, when we write an essay, we must be sure that our readers can empathize—as in relate to or identify with—with whom we are and what we say.

The most compelling, persuasive essays are those that develop partnerships with their writers.



CC cottonbro studio "Two Kids Reading a Fairy Tale Book"

Enriching Our Lives⁸

*"Writing, the art of communicating thoughts to the mind through the eye, is the great invention of the world . . . enabling us to converse with the dead, the absent, and the unborn, at all distances of time and space."*⁹

Abraham Lincoln, "Second Lecture on Discoveries and Inventions"



Source: Picasso, *Reading the Letter*, Picasso.net
(<https://www.pablopicasso.net/reading-the-letter/>)

What Is Empathy?

*"Learning to stand in somebody else's shoes, to see through their eyes, that's how peace begins. And it's up to you to make that happen. Empathy is a quality of character that can change the world."*¹⁰

Barack Obama

(See "Notes Page View" To read President Obama's observations on this encounter and its significance.)



Photo: Pete Souza,¹¹ Obama Foundation
(<https://www.obama.org/discover/stories/jacob-philadelphias/>)

Empathy and Creativity: Attention

"Empathy begins with attention. Creativity does too. In both cases, you pay attention to the data you take in. In Latin, attention means to 'stretch toward.' When you empathize with someone, you're stretching outside of yourself and stretching into that person's world. This empathy then links to problem-solving because you must first decide not only what the problem is, but who has the problem."¹²

Chris Adkins, "How does empathy influence creativity?," "A Scholar's Perspective"



CC Andrea Piacquadio, "Woman Draw a Light Bulb in Light Bulb"

Empathy and Creativity: Connection

Creativity is just connecting things. When you ask creative people how they did something, they feel a little guilty because they didn't really do it, they just saw something. It seemed obvious to them after a while. That's because they were able to connect experiences they've had and synthesize new things."¹³

Steve Jobs, co-founder, former chairman and CEO of Apple Computer



CC affen ajlf, "brain 22"

Empathy, Creativity, and Multiple Perspectives



Photo: Screen Grab from "Shake up Your Story" video.

"Shake Up Your Story"¹⁴

Raghava KK on Creativity and Empathy



Photo: Nimash Jain for the National Geographic
<https://education.nationalgeographic.org/resource/artist-raghava-kk/>

"Shake Up Your Story"



Photo: Screen Grab from "Shake up Your Story" video.

Launch Video Here—

https://www.ted.com/talks/raghava_kk_shake_up_your_story?language=en

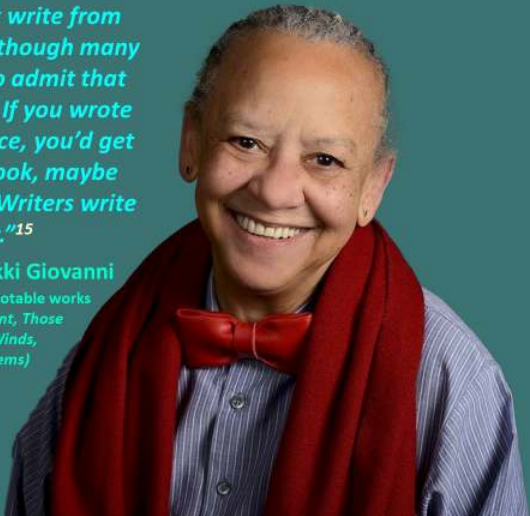
20

"Writers don't write from experience, although many are hesitant to admit that they don't . . . If you wrote from experience, you'd get maybe one book, maybe three poems. Writers write from empathy."¹⁵

Nikki Giovanni

(Some of Giovanni's notable works include *Black Judgment*, *Those Who Ride the Night Winds*, and *Bicycles: Love Poems*)

Photo—Nikki Giovanni from
<https://www.nikki-giovanni.com/>

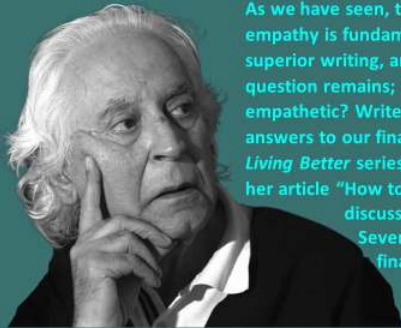


Cultivating Empathy

*"Research has shown that empathy makes people better managers and workers, and better family members and friends. But it's bigger than just its personal effect. We're all in this together, and researchers say that connection and compassion are crucial to a sustainable and humane future."*¹⁶

Claire Cain Miller, "How to Be More Empathetic"

As we have seen, there is abundant evidence that empathy is fundamental to knowing your audience, superior writing, and creativity. However, a key question remains; how do we become more empathetic? Writer Claire Cain Miller offers some answers to our final challenge. As part of its *A Year of Living Better* series, *The New York Times* published her article "How to Be More Empathetic", which discusses steps to fostering empathy. Several them are summarized in the final three slides.



CC Ingrid Lowis, "Skeptical"

22

Cultivating Empathy

Miller recommends direct action and self-evaluation:

- Discover how people different from you think and live by engaging them in sincere and open conversation and following them on social media.
- If you find that someone's behavior, beliefs, or feelings upset you, strive to determine where they are coming from. Consider their backgrounds, their daily challenges, and past experiences.
- Become more attentive to others, especially in conversations. Be careful to observe non-verbal clues.
- Explore unfamiliar environments and cultures through new experiences, such as attending a house of worship of another religion or attending an event of another culture, such as a Pride Parade, a Cinco de Mayo festival, or a Bar/Bat Mitzvah.



CC Anyane Vilarim, "Close-up Portrait Photo of Woman in White Collared Top"

Cultivating Empathy (Part 2)

She suggests involvement community activities and reading literary fiction:

- Read books that enable you to discover how others live and think. Research has demonstrated that people who read literary fiction are more empathetic than those who do not. Several medical schools, for example, encourage future physicians to read narrative fiction, because it helps them develop superior bedside manners and diagnostic skills.
- Volunteer for community efforts, such as a community garden, a food pantry, an advocacy group, or a school board. For example, participating in events involving people in need is an excellent way to engage directly with the home-less and others who are economically or socially disadvantaged.
- Recognize that all people including ourselves, are biased. We all grow up in singular environments isolated from other cultures.



CC Andreea Placquadro, "Portrait Photo of Woman in Red Top Wearing Black Framed Eyeglasses Standing In Front of White Background Thinking"

24

Cultivating Empathy (Part 3)

Miller finds rigorous self-evaluation to be especially illuminating:

- Accept the fact that you have biases and strive to identify and address them.
- Since we are often unaware of our own biases, explore ways to discover them. You could take a quiz designed to help you reveal their unconscious biases.¹⁷ Examine your behavior in social situations, think about cultural differences, and how you respond to cultural stimuli. Consider these questions
 - Do you ever contemplate issues related to race, sexual orientation, ethnicity, gender, and access? How often?
 - Do you watch movies, plays, or TV shows or read books that portray people of diverse cultures?
 - Do you ever find yourself in social settings with people who identify differently than you?

(Links to quizzes and other resources for identifying personal biases are available in the "Notes Page View".)

 Pranav Dikwal, "Man Wearing Black Formal Suit Jacket"



This page titled [2.2: Empathy--In-Class Activity](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC-SA](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Paul Butera](#).

2.3: Empathy--Assignment

We have discussed the importance of knowing your audience to write a persuasive essay. Your goal is to form partnerships with your readers, and that requires you to study your audience. Your understanding of their backgrounds, needs, and preferences should guide your essay's strategy, research, structure, tone, and word choice. The best way to develop this understanding is to use empathy. This is especially true if your audience includes people with different cultures and backgrounds than yours.

Strong writers focus on nurturing their empathy and learning how other people think. This includes working to identify your personal biases. Thus, they often examine their behaviors in social situations and review attitudes to assess their level of empathy and how well they relate to people from other cultures.

Your in-class assignment is to do your own self-evaluation of your own level of empathy and summarize your conclusions in a short essay of about 300 words. Here are a few questions to get you started. We do not expect you to answer any or all of these questions. They are intended to jumpstart your thinking.

- Do you ever contemplate issues related to race, sexual orientation, ethnicity, gender, and access? How often?
- Do you watch movies, plays, or TV shows or read books that portray people of diverse cultures?
- Do you ever find yourself in social settings with people of other backgrounds or preferences?
- Are you attentive to others, especially in conversations? Are you aware of non-verbal clues?
- When you disagree with someone or find the behavior and attitudes off-putting, do you get angry and dismiss them or do you try to understand where they are coming from?
- If someone takes a position on an issue that is counter to your own, do you reject it out-of-hand or do you consider it seriously and see if your views need adjustment?

This page titled [2.3: Empathy--Assignment](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC-SA 1.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Paul Butera](#).

CHAPTER OVERVIEW

3: Critical Thinking- A Vital Skill for the Information Age--by Paul Butera

Critical thinking is an essential capability. It is an invaluable skill for you as a student, a writer, and as a contributing member of your community. This is especially true today because of the deluge of information that we must sift through every day to find the truth. Modern technologies and the ubiquity of misinformation and disinformation, which often divide people and maintain the imbalance of power that restricts opportunities for less favored groups. Thus, the ability to look at evidence, evaluate the trustworthiness of a source, and think critically is one of the most vital skills required for future success and the creation of an inclusive community.

[3.1: Critical Thinking- a Vital Skill for the Information Age--Readings](#)

[3.2: Critical Thinking- a Vital Skill for the Information Age--Classroom Activity](#)

[3.3: Critical Thinking--Assignment](#)

This page titled [3: Critical Thinking- A Vital Skill for the Information Age--by Paul Butera](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC-SA 1.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Paul Butera](#).

3.1: Critical Thinking- a Vital Skill for the Information Age--Readings

Critical Thinking: A Vital Skill for the Information Age

By Paul J. Butera, PhD

Richard J. Daley College, one of the City Colleges of Chicago

Why is critical thinking important?

Critical thinking is an essential capability. It is an invaluable skill for you as a student, a writer, and as a contributing member of your community. This is especially true today because of the deluge of information that we must sift through every day to find the truth. Modern technologies and the ubiquity of misinformation and disinformation, which often divide people and maintain the imbalance of power that restricts opportunities for less favored groups. Thus, the ability to look at evidence, evaluate the trustworthiness of a source, and think critically is one of the most vital skills required for future success and the creation of an inclusive community.

We often must make tough decisions on what is best for us, our families, and our communities. For whom should we vote? What university should we choose? Should we get involved in a neighborhood controversy? What is the right vocation for us? We are always making choices, and we often must base our decisions on information with a hidden agenda that meets someone else's needs and not ours. At the same time, we must struggle with our own subjective perspectives, and we favor information and opinions that confirm previously held beliefs and biases. As the Reverend Martin Luther King warned us, "To think incisively and to think for oneself is difficult. We are prone to let our mental life become invaded by legions of half-truths, prejudices, and propaganda" ("The Purpose of Education" ¹).

Thus, we are challenged to become critical thinkers if we are to manage the daily barrage of misinformation and disinformation and become thoughtful and informed citizens. But what does it mean to be a critical thinker and what are the attributes we should emulate?

In general, critical thinkers engage in a straightforward process:

1. They evaluate issues from a variety of perspectives.
2. They examine issues in terms of their contexts (historical, cultural, political, social, etc.).
3. They review their own personal assumptions and biases to ensure that their personal perspective is not influencing their assessment.
4. They formulate conclusions based on all the examined evidence without personal bias.

The Qualities of Critical Thinkers

As Dr. King emphasized, this is not a painless process, and it requires dedication and commitment to, at least, six practices or qualities: rationality, self-awareness, broad-mindedness, discipline, engagement, and skeptical independence. Table One provides greater detail on these practices.

Quality	Critical Thinkers
Rationality	• rely on reason rather than emotion. • require evidence, ignore no known evidence, and follow it where it leads. • are concerned more with finding the best explanation than being right. • analyze apparent confusion and contradictions and ask questions.
Self-Awareness	• weigh the influences of motives and bias. • recognize their own assumptions, prejudices, biases, and points of view.
Broad-Mindedness	• evaluate all reasonable inferences. • consider a variety of viewpoints or perspectives. • remain open to alternative interpretations. • do not reject unpopular views out of hand.

Discipline	• are precise, meticulous, comprehensive, and exhaustive. • resist manipulation and irrational appeals. • avoid snap judgments.
Engagement	• are active, not passive, ask questions, analyze, and consciously apply tactics and strategies to uncover meaning or assure their understanding. • are open to innovative ideas and perspectives and are willing to challenge their beliefs and investigate competing evidence.
Independence and Skepticism	• recognize the relevance and/or merit of alternative assumptions and perspectives. • recognize the extent and weight of evidence. • approach texts or internet content with the same skepticism and suspicion as they approach spoken remarks.

Of course, one way to understand what critical thinkers do is to look at what they do not. That is, what are the characteristics of non-critical thinkers and what practices should one avoid. In general, non-critical thinkers tend to be hidebound and dogmatic. They see things in black or white, avoid complexity and nuance, and are insular and isolated. Since they are totally committed to their viewpoint and ideas, they fear anything that challenges their beliefs and are inclined to avoid evidence that contradicts their position. In a debate, they rely on intellectually dishonest tactics and are fond of logical fallacies, such as attacking their opponents' motives or character.

How to Be a Critical Thinker

There are many attributes that separate critical thinkers from non-critical. In particular, critical thinkers are dedicated to finding the truth. Consequently, they are engaged and committed to evaluating what they read or hear to ensure its integrity before they use it. One question remains: How do critical thinkers determine the veracity of content and the credibility of a source? One approach is the Five-Step CRAAP process, which consists of five sets of questions:

1. **Current**—When was the material published? Is the information dated?
2. **Relevant**—Is the information related to your topic? Is it written for an appropriate audience? Is the material advanced enough for your needs? Or is it too advanced for your audience?
3. **Authoritative**—Who is the author (or authors)? Who or what organization was it written for? Are they credible? Has it been peer reviewed? Did an organization or individual sponsor the content? If so, what is their agenda? Is the information surprising and counter to common knowledge?
4. **Accurate**—What are the sources of the information? Are there references? Is the statistical evidence solid? Has it been “cherry picked?” Does it meet statistical standards? Is the sample size sufficient and appropriate? Was the methodology solid?
5. **Purposes**—Why was the source created? Was the reference written to inform, sell something, advance an opinion, or entertain? Is there a hidden agenda? Can you identify any bias?

Focusing on the CRAAP criteria can reveal issues that can lead you to reject sources or handle the information carefully. For example, the Greening Earth Society, which closed its doors in 2005, purported to be “a non-profit organization whose goal is to make our life, our environment and our energy greener” (“Welcome to Greening Earth Society”²). However, a quick review of the society’s website disclosed that the sponsoring organization had an agenda different from the one implied by the welcoming statement. The sponsor of the society was Western Fuels Association. Its current mission is “To champion our members and provide exceptional benefit by acquiring and transporting fuel at the lowest possible cost.”³ When the Society existed, the Association's focus was “to mitigate the impact of initiatives and legislation that would increase the delivered cost of coal and subsequently increase the price of electricity.”⁴ The Society and Western Fuels were closely aligned, sharing both office space and leadership. Moreover, their agenda seems to have been shared as well. According to SourceWatch, the Greening Earth Society claimed that greenhouse gas emissions promoted plant growth and would create a greener environment, a theory ridiculed by most climate scientists.⁵

Critical thinkers are also alert to startling statements that seem too good to be true or are counter to accepted truth. You should not reject them out of hand, but you should check them out. For example, the following statement appeared in the October 1, 2019, issue of *Firearms News*:

In news unsurprising to anyone familiar with crime statistics, the recent FBI data revealed five times as many deaths are caused by knives than guns according to a recent *Breitbart News* article.⁶

In fact, despite the magazine's assertion, it is unlikely that most people familiar with crime statistics would find it surprising that killers use knives in five times as many murders in the United States as guns. This is the kind of statement that should lead a critical thinker to check the source of the data to determine accuracy. *Breitbart News* said that, in 2018, guns were used to kill 297 people in the United States, while 1,515 were killed by knives. The *News* cited the Federal Bureau of Investigation's (FBI) as its source. The figures come from the Criminal Justice Information Services Division's "Expanded Homicide Data Table 8."⁷ The table connects U.S. murder victims to the weapons used to kill them. If you checked the Table, you would discover that the figure of 297 cited a the number of people killed by *guns* is, in fact, the number killed by *rifles*. The change of the word from "rifles" to "guns" made an enormous difference. In fact, murders use guns to kill 10,265 people in the United States in 2018, more than 6.5 times those committed with knives that year. Sometimes this change may have been deliberate. Other times it may have been a matter of carelessness or ignorance. Headline writers, whose goal is to attract readers, often used "guns" when the article itself specifies "rifles." In addition, rifles have two more letters than guns and take up more of a newspaper's precious space.

Critical thinkers are also often wary of statistical evidence, which, at times, can be technically true but still be misleading, which has given rise to the cliché, "Lies, damn lies, and statistics." Pundits and politician have often emphasized that the number of white people who die in fatal police shooting is higher than the number of Black people, suggesting that people of color do not suffer disproportionate amounts of police violence. However, according to Statista, the rate per million of the population of Black individuals killed (5.8) by police is 2.5 times that of White people (2.3). Since the White population is much larger than the Black one, absolute numbers do not prove that Whites are just as likely to be fatally shot by police as Black people.⁸

These examples of misinformation and disinformation remind us that critical thinking requires rigor and demanding work, but the toughest challenge we face as critical thinkers is confirmation bias. We evaluate content through the lens of our existing beliefs and favor information that confirms our previously held beliefs and biases. In *USA Today*, Jeff Stibel points out that, "Confirmation bias is evolutionary efficient . . . Reinforcing what we already know helps us make good decisions quickly."⁹ Since confirmation bias is, in general, helpful, it is particularly difficult to determine when it is subconsciously urging us to reject good information and make a wrong decision. Consequently, we should strive to identify our own biases and evaluate how they influence our reasoning. Bernard Marr encourages us "to think objectively about [our] likes and dislikes, preferences, and beliefs, and consider how these might affect [our] thinking."¹⁰

Clearly, our information-inundated society requires us to become astute thinkers who are cautious and curious. We agree with Dr. King that we must be independent thinkers, and we are careful to check sources, identify the agenda behind what we read, see, and hear, and be wary of our own emotional responses to content. We also identify a list of sources that we know to be reputable and committed to inclusive, objective reporting, and we use these sources to assess information from those with which we are unfamiliar or have less confidence.

Most of all, we are alert to biases in ourselves that arise from the influences of our social, political, economic, or cultural backgrounds. We endeavor to root out untruths inspired by bigotry or ignorance, and we seek to understand the perspectives of others who are different from us in various ways, such as race, ethnicity, gender, sexual orientation, religion, and mental and physical abilities.

Works Cited

¹Martin Luther King, Jr., "The Purpose of Education", *The Papers of Martin Luther King, Jr. Volume I: Called to Serve, January 1929-June 1951*, The Martin Luther King, Jr. Research and Education Institute, Stanford University, January 1, 1947 to February 28, 1947 <https://kinginstitute.stanford.edu/king-papers/documents/purpose-education#:~:text=To%20think%20incisively%20and%20to,education%20is%20fulfilling%20its%20purpose.>

²The Greening Earth Society, This information is from the original website, which no longer exists. Archived pages of the defunct website are available at the Web Archive here—http://web.archive.org/web/20230000000000*/http://www.greeningearthsociety.org

³Western Fuels Association, "Mission," <https://www.westernfuels.org/about#Mission>

⁴Greening Earth Society original website.

⁵“Greening Earth Society”, SourceWatch, The Center for Media and Democracy, February 25, 2020 https://www.sourcewatch.org/index.php/Greening_Earth_Society

⁶Jim Grant, “Knives are Five times more dangerous than Guns,” Editorial, *Firearms News*, October 1, 2019 <https://www.firearmsnews.com/editori...an-guns/368276>

⁷“Expanded Homicide Data: Table 8”, 2018 Crime in the United States, Criminal Justice Information Services Division, Federal Bureau of Investigation, U. S. Department of Justice. <https://ucr.fbi.gov/crime-in-the-u.s...ta-table-8.xls>

⁸“Rate of fatal police shootings in the United States from 2015 to July 2023, by ethnicity(*per million of the population per year*)”, Statista Research Department, August 1, 2023 <https://www.statista.com/statistics/1123070/police-shootings-rate-ethnicity-us/>

⁹Jeff Stibel, “Fake news: How our brains lead us into echo chambers that promote racism and sexism”, *USATODAY*, May 15, 2018 <https://www.usatoday.com/story/money/columnist/2018/05/15/fake-news-social-media-confirmation-bias-echo-chambers/533857002/>

¹⁰Bernard Marr, “13 Easy Steps to Improve Your Critical Thinking Skills”, *Forbes*, August 5, 2022 <https://www.forbes.com/sites/bernard...h=210171665ecd>

This page titled [3.1: Critical Thinking- a Vital Skill for the Information Age--Readings](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC-SA 1.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Paul Butera](#).

3.2: Critical Thinking- a Vital Skill for the Information Age--Classroom Activity

This slideshow is available for download as a [PowerPoint file here](#).



NOTE:

*Please Refer to PowerPoint's "Note Page View" for
Additional Resources, References, and
Fair Use Clarifications.*

Critical thinking is an essential capability. It is an invaluable skill For you as a student and, especially, as a contributing member of your community.

Depositphotos, Inc. Stock



Why Is Critical Thinking Invaluable?



Depositphotos, Inc. Stock

"With the sheer volume of information that we're bombarded with on a daily basis – and with the pervasiveness of fake news and social media bubbles – the ability to look at evidence, evaluate the trustworthiness of a source, and think critically is becoming more important than ever. This is why, for me, critical thinking is one of the most vital skills to cultivate for future success."¹



Disinformation Drives Strife and Division

"Racialized disinformation perpetuates and gives rise to inequalities, seeks to consolidate power among ruling classes, and sustains white supremacy. Communities of color globally face the brunt of the persecution and violence underpinned by mis- and disinformation on platforms that continue to reward and benefit monetarily from incendiary content."²

Asian American Disinformation Table



Let Us Clarify Terms

- **Misinformation**—false content that people spread by accident—or—satire, jokes, or rumors that are perceived erroneously as truth.
- **Disinformation**—false content deliberately spread to promote an agenda, hide the truth, influence public opinion, or undermine the reputations of a group of people or an individual.³

Disinformation may be hazardous to your nation's health.



Examples of Disinformation Campaigns

- Russia's Internet Research Agency (IRA) exploited American racial divisions to influence the 2016 presidential election. According to Craig Timberg and Issac Stanley-Becker, the IRA "urged Black voters to skip the election". It ran a Facebook ad on Election Day that stated, "Don't go to vote. Only this way we can change the way of things..."⁴
- A fake article, purporting to be from Canadian news outlet *Global News*, carried the headline: "Experts say not including pronouns in your bio, email, signature are (*sic*) a sign of bigotry."⁵ The apparent purpose was to further isolate the transgender community.
- In October 2019, a video of a child covered in ice became viral a second time when it was shared with the false claim, "Around 300 hundred kids found frozen alive for the purposes of selling organs for transplantation."⁶

The Experts Agree—We Need Critical Thinkers



Boris Chalepin
(1904–1979),
Teacher Resources,
National Portrait
Gallery

*"Responsibility to yourself means refusing to let others do your thinking, talking, and naming for you; it means learning to respect and use your own brains and instincts; hence, grappling with hard work."*⁸

Adrienne Rich



Stuart Ramson, File 2006,
Associated Press

*"To think incisively and to think for one's self is very difficult. We are prone to let our mental life become invaded by legions of half-truths, prejudices, and propaganda."*⁷

Martin Luther King, Jr.

The Wisdom of Pooh

Even A. A. Milne, the voice of Winnie the Pooh, offered advice on critical independent thinking.

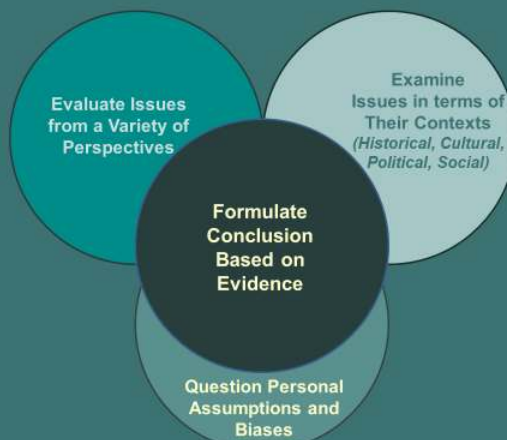
*"I wrote somewhere once that the third-rate mind is only happy when it is thinking with the majority. A second-rate mind is only happy when it is thinking with the minority. A first-rate mind is only happy when it is thinking."*⁹

A. A. Milne



Pooh and Christopher Robin,
Ernest Howard Shepard
(British, 1879–1976)

The Critical Thinking Process



10

Becoming a Critical Thinker

Thus, we are challenged to become critical thinkers if we are to avoid becoming overwhelmed by the daily barrage of misinformation and disinformation and become thoughtful and informed citizens. So, let us review their attributes and develop a model to guide our evolution.



Depositphotos,
Inc. Stock

11

The Attributes of Critical Thinkers

Critical Thinkers

Are Rational and

- rely on reason rather than emotion
- require evidence, ignore no known evidence, and follow it where it leads
- are concerned more with finding the best explanation than being right
- analyze apparent confusion and contradictions and ask questions.

Are Self-aware and

- weigh the influences of motives and bias
- recognize our own assumptions, prejudices, biases, or point of view.

Keep an Open Mind and

- evaluate all reasonable inferences
- consider a variety of possible viewpoints or perspectives
- remain open to alternative interpretations
- do not reject unpopular views out of hand

12

Emphasize Discipline and

- are precise, meticulous, comprehensive, and exhaustive
- resist manipulation and irrational appeals
- avoid snap judgments

Evaluate and

- recognize the relevance and/or merit of alternative assumptions and perspectives
- recognize the extent and weight of evidence
- approach texts or internet content with the same skepticism and suspicion as they approach spoken remarks

Engage and

- are **active**, not passive, ask questions, analyze, and consciously apply tactics and strategies to uncover meaning or assure their understanding
- are **open** to new ideas and perspectives and are willing to challenge their beliefs and investigate competing evidence.

13

Emphasize Discipline and

- are precise, meticulous, comprehensive, and exhaustive
- resist manipulation and irrational appeals
- avoid snap judgments

Evaluate and

- recognize the relevance and/or merit of alternative assumptions and perspectives
- recognize the extent and weight of evidence
- approach texts or internet content with the same skepticism and suspicion as they approach spoken remarks

Engage and

- are **active**, not passive, ask questions, analyze, and consciously apply tactics and strategies to uncover meaning or assure their understanding
- are **open** to new ideas and perspectives and are willing to challenge their beliefs and investigate competing evidence.

13

Non-Critical Thinkers?

- see things in black and white and either-or,
- are insular and isolated,
- avoid complexity and nuance,
- fail to see linkages between diverse elements and concepts,
- cherry-pick facts,
- refuse to see other perspectives and goals as potentially valid
- employ intellectually-dishonest debating tactics: change the subject, question their opponents' motives, make personal attacks, rely on slogans and catchphrases, avoid answering direct questions, use convoluted and confusing language and logic, and are deliberately vague.

14

Let's Review Practices of Critical Thinkers

Critical thinkers are suspicious and evaluate what they read to ensure its integrity. You can employ the **Five CRAAP Criteria** to evaluate the veracity of content and the credibility of the source.

1. **Current**—When was the material published? Is the information dated?
2. **Relevant**—Is the information related to your topic? Is it written for an appropriate audience? Is the material advanced enough for your needs?
3. **Authoritative**—Who is the author (or authors)? Who or what organization was it written for? Are they credible? Has it been edited or peer reviewed? If it is a website, who is the sponsor?
4. **Accurate**—What are the sources of the information? Are there references?
5. **Purposes**—Why was the source created? Was the reference written to inform, sell something, advance an opinion, or entertain? Is there a hidden agenda? Can you identify any bias?

15

Check the Sponsor of the Content

This organization appears to be an excellent source for information on making our “life, our environment and our energy greener.”¹⁰



A Conflicting Agenda

However, if you searched the website to identify the sponsor, you would discover that the sponsoring organization likely has an agenda different from the one implied by the welcoming statement. The Greening Earth Society shared offices with the Western Fuels Association, as well as the same leader.

Greening Earth Society was a creation of the Western Fuels Association

Its mission is "To provide a reliable supply of delivered coal at the lowest prudent cost."

The Association "has a tradition of standing with its members to mitigate the impact of initiatives and legislation that would increase the delivered cost of coal and subsequently increase the price of electricity."



Duplicitious Web Sites

According to SourceWatch, the Greening Earth Society, which closed its doors in 2005, claimed that greenhouse gas emissions promoted plant growth and would create a greener environment, a theory ridiculed by most climate scientists.¹¹



Be Alert for Shocking Statements

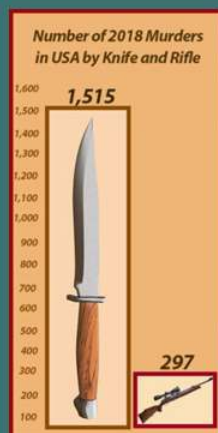
If you read a startling statement that surprises you and undermines a common belief, do not reject it out of hand but check it out. The following statement appeared in the October 1, 2019, issue of *Firearms News*

"In news unsurprising to anyone familiar with crime statistics, the recent FBI data revealed five times as many deaths are caused by knives than guns according to a recent Breitbart News article."¹²

Firearms News, October 1, 2019

19

Be Alert for Shocking Statements



In fact, most people would likely find it surprising that knives are used in five times as many murders in the United States as guns.

A critical thinker would check the source of the data to determine if the interpretation of the original information was correct.

20

We Check the Original Source

We discover that the 297 figure refers to rifles and not guns!¹³

2018 CRIME in the UNITED STATES

Criminal Justice Information Services Division | Feedback | Contact Us | Data Quality Guidelines | UCR Home

Home | Offenses Known to Law Enforcement | Arrests | Crises | Firearms | Hate Crimes | Terrorism | Police Services Data

Expanded Homicide Data Table 8

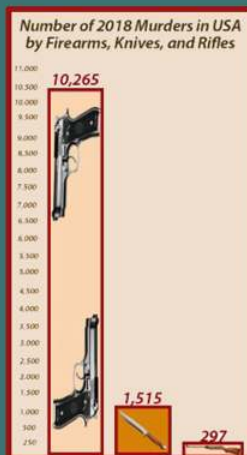
Murder Victims by Weapon, 2014-2018

Download Excel

Weapons	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018
Total	15,195	14,123			
Total Firearms	10,265	9,176	8,792	7,861	6,601
Handguns	225	251	267	254	235
Rifles	86	151	172	180	187
Shotguns	1,890	1,540	1,500	1,500	1,500
Other guns					
Firearms, type not stated					
Knives or cutting instruments					

21

Confusion over Guns



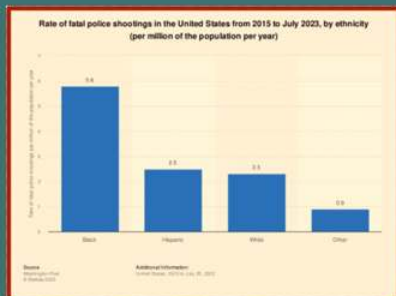
The change of the word from “rifles” to “guns” made a huge difference. In fact, firearms were used in 10,265 murders in the United States in 2018, more than 6.5 times those committed with knives that year.

Sometimes, this change may have been deliberate. Other times it was a likely a matter of carelessness or ignorance. Headline writers, whose goal is to attract readers, often used “guns” when the article itself specified “rifles”. Rifles is also two letter longer than guns and would take up more of a headline’s precious space.

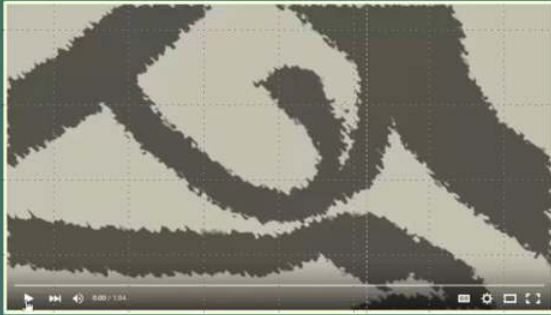
22

Lies, Damn Lies and Statistics

Statistical evidence can be technically true but still be misleading. Pundits and politician have often emphasized that the number of white people who die in fatal police shooting is higher than the number of Black people. However, as indicated in this chart from Statista, the rate per million of the population of Black individuals killed (5.8) by police is 2.5 times that of White people (2.3). Since the White population is much larger than the Black one, absolute numbers do not prove that Whites are just as likely to be fatally shot by police as Blacks.¹⁴



23

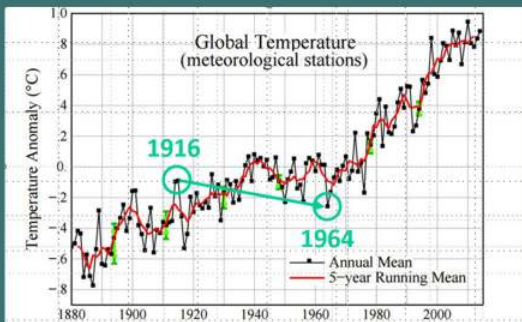


Please Visit [TeddyTV for NRK. Animation by Ole Christoffer Haga](https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=e0vj-0imOLw)
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=e0vj-0imOLw>

When evaluating statistics, you must be careful that the figures are not cherry picked. For example, some have argued that a cool summer disproves climate change. This short video by Teddy for NRK (the Norwegian Broadcasting Corporation) shows that weather can be a variation from the long-term, observable trend (climate change).¹⁵

Use Statistics with Care

Even long-term trends can be cherry picked. For example, if you selected and isolated the 40-year trend from 1916 to 1964, you could emphasize the one-degree drop, which is counter to the actual trend over 140 years.¹⁶



The Biggest Challenge

Confirmation bias is likely the toughest challenge we face as critical thinkers. We evaluate content through the lens of our existing beliefs. We favor information that confirms previously held beliefs and biases. In USA Today, Jeff Stibel points out that, "Confirmation bias is evolutionary efficient . . . Reinforcing what we already know helps us make good decisions quickly."¹⁷



26

Meeting the Challenge

Since confirmation bias is, in general, helpful, it is particularly difficult to determine when it is subconsciously urging us to reject good information and make a wrong decision. Consequently, we should strive to identify our own biases and evaluate how they influence our reasoning. Bernard Marr encourages us "to think objectively about [our] likes and dislikes, preferences, and beliefs, and consider how these might affect [our] thinking."¹⁸



Depositphotos, Inc. Stock

27

Enhancing our Critical Thinking Skills

Clearly, our information inundated society requires us to become astute thinkers who are cautious and curious. We agree with Milne and Dr. King that we must be independent thinkers, and we are careful to check sources, identify the agenda behind what we read, see, and hear, and be wary of our own emotional responses to content. We also identify a list of sources that we know to be reputable and committed to inclusive, objective reporting, and we use these sources to test information from those with which we are unfamiliar or have less confidence.

Depositphotos, Inc. Stock

(Adobe Stock)

28

Enhancing our Critical Thinking Skills

Clearly, our information inundated society requires us to become astute thinkers who are cautious and curious. We agree with Milne and Dr. King that we must be independent thinkers, and we are careful to check sources, identify the agenda behind what we read, see, and hear, and be wary of our own emotional responses to content. We also identify a list of sources that we know to be reputable and committed to inclusive, objective reporting, and we use these sources to test information from those with which we are unfamiliar or have less confidence.



Enhancing our Critical Thinking Skills

Most of all, we are alert to biases in ourselves that arise from the influences of our social, political, economic, or cultural backgrounds. We endeavor to root out untruths inspired by bigotry or ignorance, and we seek to understand the perspectives of others who are different from us in various ways, such as race, ethnicity, gender, sexual orientation, religion, and mental and physical abilities.



This page titled [3.2: Critical Thinking- a Vital Skill for the Information Age--Classroom Activity](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC-SA 1.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Paul Butera](#).

3.3: Critical Thinking--Assignment

1. True or False—Place a T or an F in the space to indicate whether the statement is True or False (10 Points)

- A. ___ Confirmation bias is likely the toughest challenge we face as critical thinkers.
- B. ___ Critical thinkers seek and bend evidence to fit their favored conclusion.
- C. ___ Non-Critical thinkers are known for their self-awareness.
- D. ___ Disinformation is false content deliberately spread to promote an agenda, hide truth, influence public opinion, or undermine the reputations of a group of people or an individual.
- E. ___ Statistics cannot be used in support of a false statements.

2. Why is critical thinking an especially valuable asset for you as a student and a citizen? (10 points)

3. How does critical thinking help ensure our understanding and acceptance of people different from us? (15 points)

4. Please explain why critical thinking requires discipline. (15 points)

5. What are the key attributes of critical thinkers? (10 points)

6. Please describe the critical thinking process. (15 points)

7. What is confirmation bias? (10 points)

8. Imagine you find material on a web that you want to use in your research paper. However, you have some concern that it might not be accurate. Describe at least three ways you would check its veracity. (15 points)

This page titled [3.3: Critical Thinking--Assignment](#) is shared under a [CC BY-NC-SA 1.0](#) license and was authored, remixed, and/or curated by [Paul Butera](#).

Index

A

audience

2.1: Empathy, the Key to Compelling Communication--Reading

B

Benefits of Bilingualism

1.1: Why is English so Difficult--Reading

bilingualism

1.1: Why is English so Difficult--Reading

C

communication

2.1: Empathy, the Key to Compelling Communication--Reading

critical thinking

3: Critical Thinking- A Vital Skill for the Information Age--by Paul Butera

3.1: Critical Thinking- a Vital Skill for the Information Age--Readings

3.2: Critical Thinking- a Vital Skill for the Information Age--Classroom Activity

D

diversity

3: Critical Thinking- A Vital Skill for the Information Age--by Paul Butera

3.2: Critical Thinking- a Vital Skill for the Information Age--Classroom Activity

E

empathy

2.1: Empathy, the Key to Compelling Communication--Reading

2.2: Empathy--In-Class Activity

equity

3.2: Critical Thinking- a Vital Skill for the Information Age--Classroom Activity

H

History of the English Language

1.1: Why is English so Difficult--Reading

I

inclusion

1.1: Why is English so Difficult--Reading

3.2: Critical Thinking- a Vital Skill for the Information Age--Classroom Activity

L

language

1.1: Why is English so Difficult--Reading

Linguistic Racism

1.1: Why is English so Difficult--Reading

M

misinformation

3.1: Critical Thinking- a Vital Skill for the Information Age--Readings

P

Paul Butera

2.3: Empathy--Assignment

S

social justice

3.2: Critical Thinking- a Vital Skill for the Information Age--Classroom Activity

T

the history of the English language

1.2: Why is English so Difficult?-- Classroom Activity

Detailed Licensing

Loading...